hand, marched menacingly towards Rashtrapati Bhavan. As they neared their destination their aggression correspondingly mounted and with blood-curdling war cries they broke into a run. The Akali Sikhs were protesting against the Sant Samagam (a religious congregation) held earlier by the Nirankari Sikhs, and were fired with religious zeal. Kiran Bedi, leading a squad of the Delhi Police to keep the demonstrators in tow, screamed at the onrushing Akalis to desist. Instead, they attacked the police party. While Bedi's men beat a hasty retreat, she herself charged at the mob with just a baton in her hand and an oversized helmet on her head. Despite the blows rained upon her, and in an exemplary show of courage, she held on relentlessly till the demonstrators were cowed down by her sheer guts and determination. She was soon rejoined by her squad and the situation was brought under control.

For this remarkable act of hers, over and above the call of duty, Kiran Bedi was awarded the Police Medal for Gallantry on 10 October 1980.

Kiran fondly remembers how the then police commissioner, J. N. Chaturvedi, would always encourage her to take initiatives. She attributes this award of hers to his leadership and the training she received from Gautam Kaul, one of the most admired police officers of the country.

Fourteen years later, she became the only police officer in the world to receive a *peace* award – the Magsaysay – the most prestigious of its kind in Asia, at Manila in the Philippines. It is also termed as the Nobel Prize of Asia.

The bestowing of such an award represented, to say the least, a rare combination of extremes. And yet, on closer scrutiny, one realizes that all that she was doing was what she perceived as her duty, which throughout her career she executed to the best of her abilities.

In 1986 a Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) delegation, a pro-Hindu party, led by Madan Lal Khurana (who later became the chief minister of Delhi), and other leaders, such as Kedar Nath Sahni, insisted on gathering at the Red Fort grounds and leading a massive procession into the nearby Muslim-dominated areas of the city. As district commissioner of police (DCP), north, she refused to give them permission. She was quite convinced that despite what anyone may claim, this procession would result in high-voltage communal tension and the police would then be hard put to restore law and order. She was adamant and so were the BJP members. They sat on a three-week *dharna* (a sit-in protest) with just a one-point charter of demands – dismiss Kiran Bedi.

Seven years later, when Kiran became the inspector general (prisons) (IGP), Khurana visited Tihar Jail as the chief minister of Delhi. He commended her on the tremendous work she had done there and also recounted the days of his *dharna*. Over the public address system he declared that she had done her duty then, and was doing her duty now. Quite a turnabout, but then, quite common for politicians!

She has exhibited rare flashes of overconfidence though, and these are the times when she has slipped up. But then, she also has this tenacious ability to fight her way out of trouble when she sees defeat writ large on the wall.

During the 1976 National Tennis Final at Chandigarh, Kiran was playing Nirupama Mankad-Vasant and had lost the first set 3-6. Kanwar Mahendra Singh Bedi and the former Asian champion, Lakshmi Mahadevan, were the radio commentators. Kanwar Mahendra asked Lakshmi whether she thought it was 'curtains' for Kiran. Lakshmi remembered a match she had played against Kiran in Assam. Kiran had lost the first set at 0-6, and was trailing 0-5 in the second. From there she had come out with a vengeance and won 0-6, 7-5, 6-0. So, asserted Lakshmi, she would not count her out. Kiran eventually beat Nirupama 3-6, 6-3, 6-1.

Lakshmi was referring to the East India Championships played in Gauhati (now Guwahati) in January 1976. Kiran's daughter, Saina, had been born in September 1975 and she was still toning